

MASTERING THE FINE ARTS OF APATHY AND COMPASSION

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Security is an illusion. There is no such thing. Anything you build can be destroyed. Anything you have can be taken away. How hard you work is irrelevant. How intelligent you are is irrelevant. How strong you are is irrelevant.

You have the things you have because other people permit it to be so. But people are fickle and may change their minds at any time. You can be the best in the world at Thing X. But if people decide that they no longer value Thing X for whatever reason, then you will face ruin and be deprived of everything, even the necessities of life itself, if not for the compassion and kindness of strangers.

So wut do?

Develop the one superpower that will always prove invaluable to you:

apathy. This isn't the lazy indifference form of apathy, but rather a wizened *detachment* form. Living in apathy doesn't mean that you don't do things; it just means that you do them without being attached to a particular outcome. You can own things, but you don't place undue importance on them. If tomorrow you wake to find all of your things burned in a fire during the night, it may be annoying, but it doesn't shatter your whole self-identity.

Living in apathy means not tying your self-worth to anything external to yourself. OK, you bought a Rolls Royce; that's a nice thing. Oh, some asshole got jealous and dropped a 10-story building on it somehow. Also, your car insurance just lapsed. Oh well. It was just a car. You have enough money left to buy a used Civic. You'll be fine.

Once you've mastered apathy and detachment, next comes *compassion*. Compassion is the logical conclusion of accepting that our lives exist in a very precarious balance that can be upset by anything or even nothing at all. It means accepting the fact that we all can be homeless. We all can be starving. So, do not judge those who have less than you as being inferior or somehow deserving of their plight for that is evil.

Feel compassion for those less fortunate and help where you can. But there's an important part here. You are just one person and the need in the world is tremendous. You do not have the resources to help everyone. Unfortunately, capitalism ensures that those who do have the resources to help everyone won't because they are, by definition, the most evil motherfuckers in the world.⁶¹ So you must not allow your compassion to outweigh your self-preservation. So, do not give on demand. Instead, decide how much you can afford to spare for the benefit of others, then proactively give that money, time, or effort on your terms.

⁶¹ Because capitalism rewards psychopathy. Therefore, only psychopaths end up with all of the resources.

"But I don't have any spare resources. Anything extra has to be put into my retirement account!"

Here's a counterintuitive concept, but it's true: **Saving money is evil.**

I hear you arguing already. Hear me out first... It's true. Saving is just a polite word for *hoarding*. By saving, you are hoarding resources because you can't trust that others will be there to pick you up if you stumble and that is the very heart of what is wrong with society and why everything sucks.⁶²

Learn to live beneath your means and give often. Practice living with less so you can *fear less*. Put compassion in your damn budget. Stop pretending you need a third pair of \$200 headphones while someone else can't afford insulin. Refusing to give to someone who is in need today because you *have to* hoard resources in order to defend yourself from some hypothetical future scenario that may never come is nothing short of evil. Saving is just compassion withheld in fear.

References:

- *Bhagavad Gītā* 2:47 — "You have the right to work, but never to the fruits of work."
- Seneca, *De Vita Beata* — wealth's only virtue lies in its correct use, not its accumulation.
- Kropotkin, *Mutual Aid* — survival of the cooperative, not the fittest.
- Alan Watts, *The Wisdom of Insecurity* — same thesis, stripped of scripture.

⁶² I fully appreciate that this is very Post-Libertarianism philosophy. But Libertarianism is for scared little children anyway, so it's best left in your sordid past.